L7

Process Discovery & Opportunity Analysis

Before you write a single line of automation, you have to *see*. Gemba walks, SIPOC diagrams, the 7-lens automatability checklist, and the Impact × Feasibility matrix — the discipline that turns guesses into fundable opportunities.

WHAT'S INSIDE

WHY DISCOVERY FIRST

₹70 lakh wasted — automating the wrong process

WASTED BUDGET

₹70 L

Spent automating processes that didn't actually move the needle.

CAUSE

Discovery

Most automation failures are not technology failures — they are discovery failures.

WHAT TO DO

Watch

Discovery is the eye. Without it, automation is blind.

OUTCOME

Right one

This lesson teaches you to find the *right* process to automate — not just any process.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to —

1. Distinguish process discovery, process mining, and task mining.
2. Conduct a Gemba observation to spot hidden work.
3. Draft a SIPOC diagram from a 30-minute interview.
4. Score processes using the 7-lens automatability checklist.
5. Place candidates on the Impact × Feasibility matrix.
6. Write a one-page Opportunity Charter that secures funding.

AGENDA

What we'll cover today

Short, sequenced parts. Each one builds on the last.

01
Three approaches
Discovery, mining and task mining — what each is best at, and when to combine them.

02
Gemba & SIPOC
Two timeless techniques: go to the work, watch it happen, then map it on one page.

03
7-lens score
The data-driven scorecard that turns 'I think this is automatable' into a defensible number.

04
Charter & funding
The Impact × Feasibility 2×2 and the one-page Opportunity Charter that gets the cheque signed.

01

PART 1 OF 4

Three approaches to seeing work

Discovery, mining and task mining — different tools, different strengths, different blind spots.

THREE PILLARS OF PROCESS ANALYSIS

Each approach answers a different question

Use the right one and the picture sharpens. Use the wrong one and the picture lies.

D

DISCOVERY

Why is this happening?

Interviews, Gemba walks, SIPOC. Best at intent, context, the 'why'. Weakest at scale and statistics.

M

MINING

What is happening at scale?

System logs from ERPs, CRMs, ticketing tools. Best at frequency and bottlenecks. Misses anything off-system.

T

TASK MINING

How is each click happening?

Desktop activity capture — clicks, copies, app switches. Best at zooming into individual workflow drudgery.

STRENGTHS & LIMITS

When to use which — and when to combine them

Most real programmes use all three. Discovery for the why, mining for the what, task mining for the how.

Approach	Best at	Weak at	Pair with
Discovery	Context & intent	Statistics & scale	Mining for volume
Mining	Volume & sequence	Off-system work	Discovery for context
Task mining	Click-by-click detail	Cross-team workflows	Discovery for purpose

02

PART 2 OF 4

Gemba — go. watch. stay quiet.

The single most underrated skill in process work. The notebook is your most valuable tool.

THE ART OF OBSERVING

Gemba means 'the real place'. The work happens there — not in the SOP.

Most process problems are invisible to managers, because the people doing the work have already adapted around them. The workaround becomes the work.

Gemba is the discipline of going to the place, watching silently, and writing down what you see — *not* what you think you see. The first 30 minutes feel awkward. Then the workarounds start appearing on every page of your notebook.

GEMBA HABITS

- Show up unannounced. Sit at the worker's elbow.
- Ask 'what's happening' rarely. Ask 'why' even more rarely.
- Capture every workaround — they are your gold.
- Time-stamp each step. Five-minute estimates lie.
- Read your notes aloud the same day or you'll forget half of it.

SIPOC IN 30 MINUTES

Five boxes. One whiteboard. The process map your team has been waiting for.

Done in this order, with one stakeholder, you'll have a usable SIPOC in under half an hour.

STEP 1

Identify the process

Choose one process with clear boundaries. Agree on where it starts and where it ends, before drawing.

→

STEP 2

List suppliers & inputs

Who feeds the process? People, systems, documents. What exactly do they hand over?

→

STEP 3

5–7 process steps

High-level only. Don't drill into clicks. The point is the shape, not the resolution.

→

STEP 4

Outputs & customers

What comes out? Who receives it — internal or external? List both.

→

STEP 5

Hand-offs & dead ends

Mark every place work changes hands, waits for approval, or loops. Those are the opportunities.

03

PART 3 OF 4

The 7-lens automatability score

Turn intuition into a number. The number turns into funding.

THE SEVEN LENSES

Score every process against seven lenses, 1 to 5

A score of 4+ on at least five lenses is fundable. Below that, fix something — or move on.

R — RULE-BASED

Decisions follow rules

Can the steps be written as if/then? If 'it depends', it's not RPA-ready yet.

D — DIGITAL

Inputs are digital

Screens, files, structured forms — yes. Phone calls and paper — no.

S — STRUCTURED

Data is structured

Tables, fixed fields, predictable layouts. Free text needs AI on top.

STABLE

Process is stable

Hasn't changed in 6+ months. Bots break when interfaces or rules shift weekly.

V — HIGH VOLUME

Volume justifies build

More cases per year = more savings. Below 1,000 cases, the math rarely works.

TIME HEAVY

Each case takes minutes

Sub-30-second tasks rarely repay the build. Look for cases that take 5+ minutes.

RECOVERABLE

Errors recoverable

If the bot makes a mistake, can a human catch it

✦ THINK · PAIR · SHARE

ACTIVITY

Score five real-world processes — high, medium or low

PROMPT

For each, decide if it scores HIGH, MEDIUM or LOW on automatability — and pick the lens that drove your verdict.

1. *Form fields are handwritten on paper*
2. *Process changes every week as new exceptions appear*
3. *Reading 4 lakh structured invoices into SAP nightly*
4. *Authorising emergency surgical procedures*
5. *Onboarding 800 new employees per quarter via a fixed checklist*

HOW TO RUN IT

1. 60s solo — score each process H/M/L.
2. 60s with a partner — defend any 'medium' calls.
3. 60s share-out — instructor calls on a team.
4. 30s reveal — instructor reveals canonical sort.

04

PART 4 OF 4

Impact × Feasibility — and the Charter that funds it

The 2×2 that decides what to fund. The one-pager that gets it approved.

DECISION TIME

Plot every candidate on Impact × Feasibility before you fund anything

Most teams build credibility with quick wins, then graduate to strategic bets. Stay out of the bottom-left.

STRATEGIC BET **High impact, low feasibility** Worth doing — but only after you've banked some quick wins. Big change, big payoff, more discovery first.	QUICK WIN **High impact, high feasibility** Fund first. Builds credibility for the programme. The 7-lens score earns its keep here.
SKIP **Low impact, low feasibility** Don't bother. The project costs more than it returns and is hard. Walk away with no guilt.	FILL-IN **Low impact, high feasibility** Use to keep the team busy between strategic bets. Cheap wins — but won't fund the programme.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A Mumbai NBFC's customer onboarding charter

THE SCENARIO

A mid-sized NBFC onboards 12,000 retail loan customers monthly. Average onboarding time: 3.4 days. Re-work rate: 17%. The team had three candidate processes — a popular one (chatbot), a loud one (lead scoring), and a quiet one (KYC document extraction). Discovery told a different story than the meetings.

THE TAKEAWAY

Gemba revealed 41% of cycle time was waiting for re-uploaded KYC documents. SIPOC + 7-lens scored KYC extraction at 4.4/5. The Charter funded a ₹38-lakh pilot. 90-day result: cycle time down to 1.2 days, re-work down to 4%.

WHAT TO NOTICE

1. Discovery surfaced the real bottleneck — not the loud one.
2. SIPOC made the wait time visible to the executive sponsor.
3. 7-lens score turned 'we should do this' into a defensible 4.4/5.
4. Charter fit on one page — sponsor signed within a week.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK · QUESTION 1 OF 3

You have one hour and one stakeholder. Which approach gives you the best understanding of *intent* in a process?

- **A** Process mining on the ERP logs
- **B** Task mining on the user's desktop
- **C** A 30-minute interview plus a 30-minute Gemba walk
- **D** A SIPOC drawn alone, without the stakeholder

ANSWER · QUESTION 1 OF 3

*You have one hour and one stakeholder. Which approach gives you the best understanding of *intent* in a process?*

CORRECT ANSWER

C

A 30-minute interview plus a 30-minute Gemba walk

WHY

Mining tells you what happened, not why. Task mining zooms into clicks. Discovery — interviews and Gemba — is the only approach that captures intent, context, and the workarounds that the logs cannot see.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK · QUESTION 2 OF 3

A candidate scores 5/5 on rule-based, digital, structured and time-heavy — but only 1/5 on stable. What should you do?

A Fund it — most lenses are strong

B Walk away — automation will break with every process change

C Fix the stability first, then re-score

D Score stability more generously to keep it alive

ANSWER · QUESTION 2 OF 3

A candidate scores 5/5 on rule-based, digital, structured and time-heavy — but only 1/5 on stable. What should you do?

C

CORRECT ANSWER

Fix the stability first, then re-score

WHY

Stability is the single biggest reason bots fail in production. Automating an unstable process is throwing money at a moving target. The senior move: stabilise the process for 60–90 days, rescore, then build.

ANSWER · QUESTION 3 OF 3

*On the Impact × Feasibility matrix, which quadrant should you fund *first*?*

CORRECT ANSWER

B

Quick Win — high impact, high feasibility

WHY

Quick wins build credibility and budget. Most successful programmes start here, then earn the right to take on Strategic Bets. Skipping straight to Strategic Bets is how programmes lose their funding before they prove their worth.

REFLECT & APPLY

Three questions before you close this lesson

Spend 60 seconds on each. Write the answers down — no scrolling, no shortcuts.

Q1	*Pick one process you've watched at work or college. What workaround had quietly become 'the work'?*
Q2	*If you had 30 minutes with one stakeholder, would you draw a SIPOC, score the 7 lenses, or just listen — and why?*
Q3	*In your context, where on the Impact × Feasibility matrix is the quietest quick win? Name it in one sentence.*

APPLY IT → ASSIGNMENT

Write a one-page Opportunity Charter for a real process

Pick a process you can observe — at work, in a college office, even at home. Run discovery: 30-minute interview, 30-minute Gemba. Build a SIPOC. Score it on the 7 lenses. Place it on the matrix. Write the one-page Charter.

DELIVERABLES

- Notes from one Gemba walk — 6+ observations, with timestamps
- Hand-drawn SIPOC with at least one hand-off and one rework loop marked
- 7-lens score with one-line justification per lens
- Impact × Feasibility placement with a one-sentence rationale
- One-page Opportunity Charter, ready to present to a sponsor

WHAT 'GOOD' LOOKS LIKE

A great Charter is one page that a busy sponsor reads in two minutes and signs in three. Sourced numbers, honest scoring, a defensible 90-day pilot.

SUMMARY

Five sentences to remember

If you remember nothing else from this lesson, remember these five lines.

1. Discovery is the eye. Without it, automation is blind.
2. Gemba — go to the work, watch silently, capture every workaround.
3. SIPOC in 30 minutes maps any process onto five boxes everyone agrees on.
4. The 7-lens score turns 'I think' into a defensible number for funding.
5. Quick wins fund the programme. Strategic bets follow — never the other way around.

END OF LESSON 7

What you can now do

Each one of these is now part of your working vocabulary.

1. Pick the right discovery tool — discovery, mining, or task mining — for any context.
2. Run a Gemba walk that captures workarounds, hand-offs and rework.
3. Draft a SIPOC in 30 minutes with one stakeholder.
4. Score any process against seven lenses with defensible justifications.
5. Place candidates on Impact × Feasibility and write a fundable Charter.

NEXT → WEEK 2 — Building your first end-to-end project